



Symptom-Based Questions

This guide provides structured questions to gather detailed information from customers about vehicle issues. Use these questions to understand symptoms and guide diagnostics. Avoid discouraged phrases like "What makes you think you need a...?" or "Have you had it inspected?" as noted below.

General Questions (Applicable to Most Symptoms)

- What is the make and model of your vehicle?
- How many miles are on your [make/model]?
- What symptoms are you experiencing?
- How long have you been experiencing these symptoms?
- Do these symptoms occur at a specific time or under specific conditions?
- Are any warning lights on? If yes, describe which ones.
- Tell me the story about your [issue/symptom]. What happened?

Instead of saying: "What makes you think you need a...?"

Say: "Tell me about the [issue/component]. What symptoms are you experiencing?"

Instead of saying: "Have you had it inspected?"

Say: "Have you had a trusted shop perform the necessary testing?"

System-Specific Questions

Check Engine Light

- Tell me the story about your check engine light. What happened?
- How long has the warning light been on?
- Is the light flashing or steady?
- Are there additional warning lights on?

Battery/Alternator (Vehicle Will Not Start)

- Tell me the story about your battery or alternator issue. What happened?
- Have you had to jump-start the vehicle?
- Is the vehicle starting?
- Does it make any noise when you try to start it?
- Are the dashboard lights on when the key is turned to the "on" position?



Brakes

- Tell me the story about your brakes, what is happening?
- Are any warning lights on?
- Are you hearing any noises? If yes:
 - When does the noise occur?
 - Where does the noise seem to come from?
 - How long have you been hearing the noise?
 - Has the noise changed over time?
- Is the steering wheel shaking? If yes, does it happen while braking or all the time?
- Does the brake pedal feel different (e.g., soft, hard, or pulsating)?
- When was your last brake inspection?
- When were your brakes last replaced?

Cooling System

- Tell me the story about your [leak, water pump, thermostat, radiator, etc.]. What happened?
- Are any warning lights on?
- What is the temperature gauge on the dashboard reading?
- Are you seeing fluid on the ground under the engine?
- Do you see steam coming from the engine?

Transmission

- Tell me the story about your transmission. What happened?
- Are any warning lights on?
- Is it automatic or manual transmission?
- Can the vehicle be driven to our shop, or will you need a tow service?
- Does the vehicle work in reverse?

Steering and Suspension

- Tell me the story about your [noise, clunk, struts, tie rod ends, ball joints, etc.]. What happened?
- Are any warning lights on?
- What symptoms are you experiencing?
- Under what conditions do these symptoms occur (e.g., when moving, turning, etc.)?
- Is the vehicle pulling to one side?
- Are you hearing any noises?



Tires

- Tell me the story about your tires. Why do they need to be replaced?
- What is the condition of your tires? Are they:
 - Worn out (tread at or below minimum)?
 - Too old (older than 8 years)?
 - Damaged (e.g., punctured and not repairable)?
- What are you looking for in a tire (e.g., performance, longevity)?
- Do you have a preferred tire brand?
- What is the size and brand of the tires currently on your vehicle?

Alignment

- Tell me the story about your vehicle's alignment. What is happening?
- Have you recently had suspension, steering, or tire work done? If yes, by whom?
- Have you noticed vibrations, pulling, or anything unusual while driving?
- Have you hit a pothole or curb?
- When was your last alignment?

Air Conditioning

- Tell me the story about your air conditioning. What is happening?
- How long has the air conditioning not been working?
- Is the air conditioning blowing warm air?
- Does the air blow at all? Does it work at high or low speeds?
- When was the last time your air conditioning was charged or repaired?

Timing Belt

- Tell me the story about your timing belt. What happened?
- Is the vehicle running normally?
- Are you replacing the timing belt due to its age or mileage?
- Do you have service records for the vehicle?
- How many miles are on your vehicle?

Emissions

- Tell me the story about your emissions issue. What is happening?
- Are any warning lights on? (If yes, refer to "Check Engine Light" questions)
- Are you noticing any symptoms?
- How long have you owned the vehicle?
- When is your vehicle registration due?
- Have you had a trusted shop perform emissions testing?

Tune-Up



- Tell me the story about your vehicle's tune-up needs. What symptoms are you experiencing?
- Are you seeking a tune-up to fix a specific problem or as routine maintenance?
- Is there anything specific you want to replace (e.g., spark plugs, filters)?
- How many miles are on your vehicle?
- Have you ever had a tune-up before?
- Are any warning lights on? (If yes, refer to "Check Engine Light" questions)
- When was the last time your vehicle was serviced?
- **Recommendation:** Would you like to schedule an oil service and inspection?

Customer-Reported Smell

- You notice the odor?
- How long have you been experiencing the smell?
- Can you describe the smell? Is it:
 - Sweet?
 - Burning?
 - Musty?
 - Plastic-like?
- Where does the smell seem to be coming from?
- What steps can you take to replicate the smell?

Engine or transmission- How much for an engine/transmission?

- Tell me more, what is going on with your engine (or Transmission)?
- Is the vehicle drivable or would it have to be towed in?
- Tell me the story about what happened with your engine/transmission.
- What sort of symptoms are you/were you having?
- How many miles do you have on your vehicle?
- Do you have a budget you are aiming for?
- Is this your everyday driver?
- Are you looking for a cheaper price or a second opinion?
- What are your long-term plans with the vehicle?
- Do you have a preference between used or new or rebuilt?
 - Based on what you are telling me, if this were my vehicle I would bring it in for testing or for an inspection
 - Another potential option, if your owner allow it, could you offer a free tow if the repair order is more than \$500 or \$1000? (Most engine or transmission repairs are more than \$1000)